PTE Academic: Tips and Strategies

A practical guide to every section, from the NextGen Nurses team

Golden rules: Speak fluently and naturally, never stay silent for more than 3 seconds, check spelling and grammar in every written answer, and practise every task type under timed conditions. Pearson updates the test from time to time, so check the current format on the official PTE website before exam day.

1. Speaking

Read Aloud

You have about 30 to 40 seconds to prepare before recording starts. Partial credit applies.

- Fluency is your top priority. Read at a steady, natural pace, not too fast and not too slow.
- Read the whole passage silently first and practise any difficult words in your head.
- Use rising and falling intonation, and stress the key facts and ideas.
- Pause briefly at commas and between sentences.
- If you stumble on a word, keep going. Do not restart the sentence.
- Use your natural voice. Do not put on an accent.

Repeat Sentence

You are scored on how many words you reproduce in the correct order.

- Listen for meaningful chunks (phrases) rather than single words.
- Copy the speaker's stress and intonation; it helps you remember the meaning.
- Speak calmly and clearly. If you miss part of the sentence, say what you remember fluently.

Describe Image

This task carries significant weight in Speaking. Aim to speak for most of the 40 seconds.

- Start with a ready-made opening: *"This graph shows..."*, *"The image illustrates..."*, *"The chart depicts..."*
- State the main purpose or title, then cover only the key points: the highest, the lowest and the overall trend.
- Use location words: *on the left, on the right, at the top, at the bottom, in the foreground, in the background, next to, above, below*.
- Use approximation words such as *about, over, under, around* so you don't need exact values.
- Build a vocabulary bank: *increase, decline, rise, fall, peak, fluctuate, trend, growth, profit, loss*.
- Finish with a short conclusion: *"Overall, the image shows that..."*
- Fluency and pronunciation matter more than covering every detail.

Retell Lecture

Another high-value Speaking task.

- Take notes on keywords only. Leave out vowels to write faster (e.g. *dvlpmnt*) and practise this skill.
- Aim to capture 3 to 5 key points.
- Step 1: give the overall topic, e.g. *"The lecture is about..."* Step 2: explain the key points in your own words.
- Simplify long names: *"Dr James Alexander says..."* can become *"The speaker says..."*
- Avoid fillers such as *umm, ahh, err*. They lower your fluency score.
- Keep talking: say something relevant to the lecture rather than going silent.

Answer Short Question

- Answers are usually one word or a short phrase. Respond quickly.
- Include articles (*a, an, the*) where they sound natural.
- If you are unsure, give your best guess using words from the question.
- Use the **NextGen Nurses Short Answer Review** bank to build general vocabulary.

2. Writing

Summarise Written Text

Write a single sentence summary of the passage.

- The answer must be **one sentence** between 5 and 75 words. Aim for about 25 to 50 words.
- Start with a capital letter and finish with a single full stop.
- Capitalise names and proper nouns.
- Focus on topic sentences and repeated words. Leave out examples, reasons and illustrations.
- Write in the third person (avoid *I* and *we*).
- Summarise each paragraph in a few words first, then join them using connectors such as *and, while, although, which*.
- Check spelling, plurals and grammar carefully.

Timing: about 3 minutes planning, 5 minutes writing, 2 minutes checking.

Write Essay

You have 20 minutes per essay; aim for 200 to 300 words.

- Identify the essay type first: opinion, advantages and disadvantages, or problem and solution.
- Use a clear structure: introduction (1 paragraph), body (2 to 3 paragraphs), conclusion (1 paragraph).
- Support each body paragraph with examples, reasons or statistics.
- Do not use bullet points.
- Use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures, and check spelling, grammar and plurals.
- Common topics to prepare: mass media, laws and behaviour, extreme sports, marketing and discounts, and exams versus written assignments.

Timing: about 3 minutes planning, 14 minutes writing, 3 minutes checking.

3. Reading

> Reading is time-pressured and the question order can vary. Prioritise the high-value fill-in-the-blank tasks and Re-order Paragraphs, and spend less time on multiple-choice, multiple-answer questions.

Reading and Writing: Fill in the Blanks / Reading: Fill in the Blanks

These carry the most marks in Reading.

- Skim the passage first for the main idea.
- Check the part of speech needed by looking at the words before and after the blank.
- Choose the word that collocates (naturally pairs) with the surrounding words.
- Look for synonyms and clues elsewhere in the text.

Timing: about 2 minutes per question.

Re-order Paragraphs

Partial credit is given for each correct adjacent pair.

- Find the topic sentence first: it introduces the subject and makes sense on its own.
- Sentences starting with pronouns (*he, she, they, this, these*) or linking words (*however, therefore*) are rarely first.
- Follow the logic: full names before pronouns, *a* before *the*, general before specific.
- Example: *"King Rama..."* comes before *"The king..."* because the first introduces who he is.
- Use time phrases (*first, later, finally*) and repeated words to link sentences.
- Aim to get at least one correct pair even if you are unsure of the full order.

Timing: about 3 to 4 minutes per question.

Multiple Choice (Single and Multiple Answers)

- Read the question first, find its keywords in the passage, then check the options.
- Be careful with extreme words such as *always, never, all, only*. Options with these are often incorrect.
- The multiple-answer version has **negative marking**: only choose options you are confident about.
- If time is short, these are the safest questions to move through quickly.

Timing: about 1.5 minutes (single) and 2 minutes (multiple).

4. Listening

Summarise Spoken Text

- Take keyword notes while listening; leaving out vowels saves time.
- Start with *"The speaker discusses..."* and cover the main idea plus key supporting points.
- Focus on topic sentences and frequently repeated words.
- Check spelling and grammar before moving on.

Timing: about 3 minutes planning, 5 minutes writing, 2 minutes checking.

Multiple Choice

- Answers are usually paraphrased, so listen for meaning, not exact words.
- Listen until the very end: key information is often given in the final part.
- Watch for extreme words (*always, never, only, all*) in the options.
- The multiple-answer version has negative marking.

Highlight Correct Summary

- Skim all options before the audio starts and note their differences.
- Listen for the main idea and repeated words, especially at the end.
- Remember the correct option will be paraphrased.

Write from Dictation

One of the highest-value Listening tasks and appears at the end, so manage your time.

- Keep your eyes open and stay focused; you hear the sentence only once.
- Write the sentence immediately, then check spelling, plurals and word endings.
- Every correctly spelled word earns marks, so write everything you heard.

Final reminder

Practice is the key. Complete at least 10 practice questions of each task type before your exam, record yourself in the Speaking tasks, and review your mistakes. Good luck from the **NextGen Nurses** team!